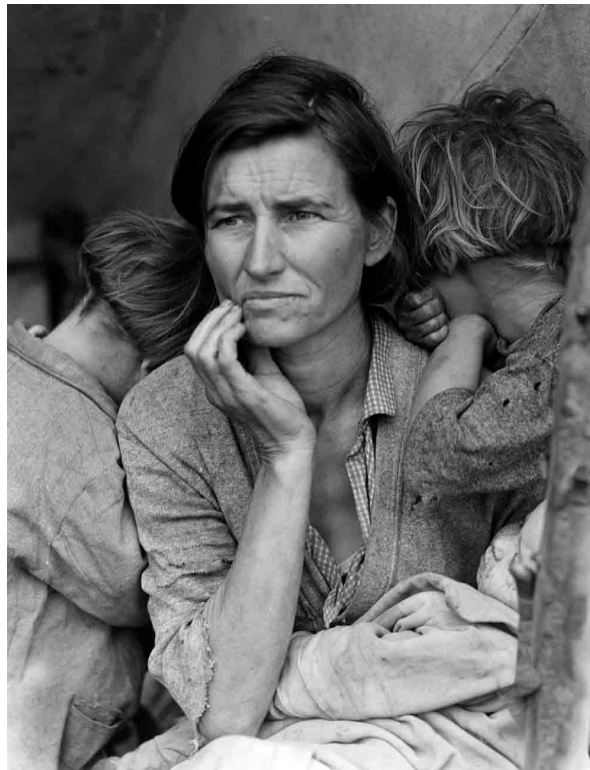




Photography

Grade 5
Photography



Los Altos School District • 201 Covington Road • Los Altos • CA • 94024 • 650.947.1195
www.losaltosartdocents.org

Last Revised: February 2025

PHOTOGRAPHY

Length: 75 minutes

Number of docents: 1

Purpose:

- To introduce students to the basic elements of photography.
- To allow students to explore and discuss a particular genre of photography and share their findings with the class.
- To allow students the opportunity to take a photograph using the elements they learned.

Academic Support: Cross curricular tie-ins with science, history, geography and vocabulary development.

Visual Arts Standards:

- Combine ideas to generate an innovative idea for art-making. (5.VA:Cr1.1)
- Identify and demonstrate diverse methods of artistic investigation to choose an approach for beginning a work of art. (5.VA:Cr1.2)
- Experiment and develop skills in multiple art-making techniques and approaches through practice. (5.VA:Cr2.1)
- Demonstrate quality craftsmanship through care for and use of materials, tools, and equipment. (5.VA:Cr2.2)
- Identify, describe, and visually document places and/or objects of personal significance. (5.VA:Cr2.3)
- Use art vocabulary to describe personal choices in artmaking and in creating artist statements. (5.VA:Cr3)
- Compare one's own interpretation of a work of art with the interpretation of others. (5.VA:Re7.1)
- Interpret art by analyzing characteristics of form and structure, contextual information, subject matter, visual elements, and use of media to identify ideas and mood conveyed. (5.VA:Re8)
- Recognize differences in criteria used to evaluate works of art depending on styles, genres, and media as well as historical and cultural contexts. (5.VA:Re9)
- Apply formal and conceptual vocabularies of art and design to view surroundings in new ways through artmaking. (5.VA:Cn10)

Unit Contains: Portfolio

Materials docent will bring:

7 photo boards, one for each Photographic Element

6 laminated sets of photos organized by **Genre**, in envelopes with **Genre** descriptions to facilitate group discussions.

Materials teacher will provide:

6 iPads

Dongle to connect iPad to classroom projector (Springer and Loyola kids can upload their photos to the teacher's Google drive and share them. The teacher can then mirror the photos to the TV from their laptop.)

Featured works:

Rule of Thirds - *Bristle Pine Tree/Taylor Swift*

Point of View - *3 Pigeon Point Lighthouse Photos*

Balancing Elements - *Little Spinner Girl at the Globe Cotton Mill/Women's Hurdles, Olympic Games*

Leading Lines - *The Bixby Bridge/The Bay Bridge/Uprooted By War, Focused on Joy*

Lighting - *Chased by the Light/La Bruja/Man Looking Directly into Camera*

Depth of Field - *Pink Cherry Blossom/Sakura Tree in Bloom*

Placement - *Surfer Girl/Trojan*

Vocabulary:

Daguerrotypes - /də'gerə,tīp/ a photograph taken by an early photographic process employing an iodine-sensitized silvered plate and mercury vapor

Rule of Thirds – a piece should be divided into nine squares of equal size, with two horizontal lines intersecting two vertical lines

Symmetry - mirror image, each side is exactly like the other

Balance - the way in which the elements in visual arts are arranged to create a feeling of equilibrium in a work of art

Pattern - anything repeated in a predictable combination.

Leading Lines – composition technique whereby the viewer's eye is attracted to lines that lead directly to the principle subject in the image.

Focal Point - the place in a work of art on which attention becomes centered because of an element emphasized in some way.

Viewpoint – the angle, direction or stance from which you choose to shoot each image.

Depth of Field – the zone of acceptable sharpness within a photo that will appear in focus

Foreground – part of a two-dimensional artwork that appears to be nearer the viewer or in the front

Middle Ground – part of a two-dimensional artwork that appears to be farther away

Background – part of a two-dimensional artwork that appears to be the farthest away

Framing – using elements of a scene to create a frame within your frame

Cropping – the removal of unwanted outer areas from a photograph

LESSON SET-UP

Docent will set up photographs and Elements Board at the front of the room. Genre folders and iPads handed out after Discussion.

PART 1: DISCUSSION OF PHOTOGRAPHIC ELEMENTS (20-25 minutes)

INTRODUCTION

- How many of you have ever taken a photograph?
- What kinds of devices can we photograph with?
- How many of you actually have a camera vs. a phone?
- How long do you think Photography has been around?

Photography has been around for almost 200 years. The first photograph was taken in 1827, by a French inventor named Joseph Niepce. However, it wasn't as easy to take a photo as it is now - it took 8 hours of light exposure for just one photo and still the photo was really fuzzy. *Show Niepce photograph.* In 1837, Louis Daguerre created a way to take sharp, but one-use images with only a 3-5 minute exposure to light. We call his photos **Daguerrotypes**.

- How did we record images and events before photography was invented?
(*through sketches, drawings, and paintings*)

With the advent of Daguerrotypes, photography could now be used to record and share images and events. We still use it that way today. But over time photography has also developed into its own art form. Photographers have created guidelines or “elements” that they follow to construct compelling photographic images.

Today we are going to learn about 7 of those photographic elements. After that we'll break into groups. Each group will get an iPad and use what you learned about these elements to apply to your own photograph. Each group will focus their photograph on a different genre. At the end, you will present your group's genre to the class and show them your photograph and the elements of photography you incorporated.

Some of these beautiful examples of photography were donated by local Los Altos photographer, Tom Waggenbrenner.

Elements of Photography

Rule of Thirds: *Bristle Pine Tree, Wagenbrenner/Taylor Swift, Annie Leibovitz*



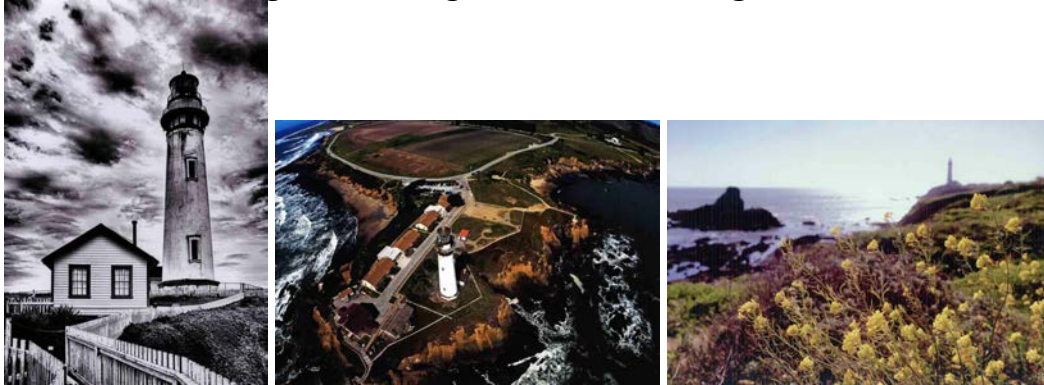
Perhaps the most basic element of photography is the rule of thirds. Imagine that your image is divided into 9 equal segments by 2 vertical and 2 horizontal lines (like a tic-tac-

toe board or the # icon). The Rule of Thirds states that the most important elements in the picture should be positioned along these lines, particularly at the points where these lines intersect. This technique adds balance and interest to the photograph. Putting the horizon along one of the horizontal lines also adds interest. Some cameras actually have a screen that will superimpose the # icon across the lens to help the photographer line up an image for the Rule of Thirds.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How did the artists use the Rule of Thirds to make these photos more interesting? Use the # transparency to show how the most important elements in the photos line up.**
- **Do you see any other photos in this lesson that have used the Rule of Thirds?**

Point of View: 3 Pigeon Point Lighthouse Photos, Wagenbrenner



Where the photographer is standing can greatly affect the message that a shot can convey. Point of view is the position the camera is in when viewing a scene. Most people take pictures at “Street” or “Eye Level.” By shooting the same image from above (Bird’s Eye), below (Worm’s Eye), up close or far away, the photographer can really change the feeling of the picture. Let’s look at three different points of view of Pigeon Point Lighthouse.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How does the feeling/mood change depending on your point of view? (e.g., bird’s eye can create a feeling of the viewer’s superiority or protectiveness vs. worm’s eye can convey objects holding power over the viewer)**
- **How can simply changing the altitude of your photo change how it looks? Can you think of an example? How might you do this when you take your own photographs later?**

Balancing Elements: *Little Spinner Girl at the Globe Cotton Mill*, Lewis W. Hine/*Women's Hurdles*, Olympic Games



Achieving balance in art, including photography is important because it means the artist has ensured that different parts of the piece command equal attention. A balanced photograph draws your eye around the entire composition. We see Symmetry and Pattern in both nature and man made environments. However, Symmetry and Pattern can be too predictable so often a photographer will “break it up” and introduce tension with an unexpected element.

They can be visually appealing especially when they are unexpected and there is a strong point of interest or **Focal Point**.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How does the artist create tension in these photographs?**
- **How did the artist achieve balance in these photographs? How did they get your eye to move around the composition?**

Leading Line: *The Bixby Bridge and The Bay Bridge*, Wagenbrenner/*Uprooted By War*, *Focused on Joy*, Bannon and Naem

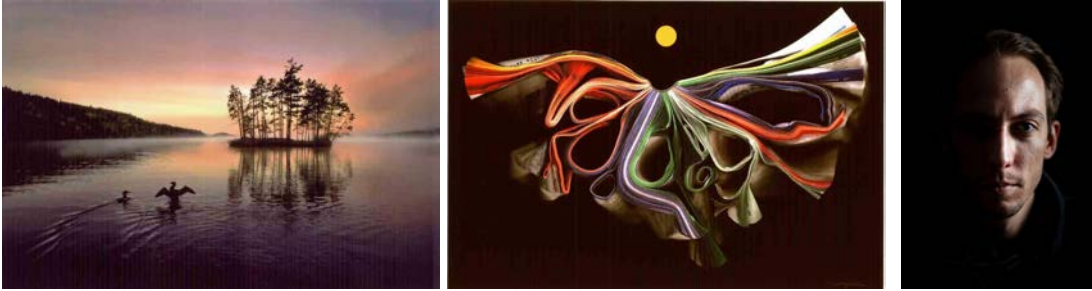


Line can be a powerful tool that can lead the viewer into the picture. Often they guide the viewer from the foreground to background toward a Focal Point. They can pull the viewer on a journey “through the scene.” Diagonal, Horizontal, Converging, Straight, Curvy, Zig-Zag, or Radial lines all affect a picture in a different way and each can be used to enhance the photo's composition.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How did the photographer lead us into these photos?**
- **Where else do you see leading lines in the photographs we've already seen? (*Little Spinner Girl*, *Pigeon Point Lighthouse*)**

Lighting: *Chased by the Light*, Jim Brandenburg/*La Bruja*, Cara Barer/*Man Looking Directly into Camera*, Peri Stojnic

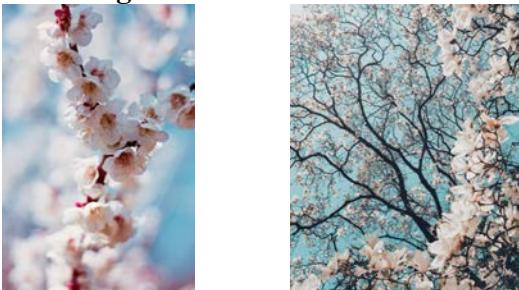


Lighting is very important and can be very complicated. It can be natural or artificial, but most important to understand is how lighting can affect the mood/feeling of a photograph. When you use **back-lighting** (light source is behind the subject) the subject is in shadow so it emphasizes their shape or silhouette, like in this landscape photograph. **Front-lighting** lights the subject straight on with few shadows, while **lighting from the side**, above or below brings out depth and patterns, and emphasizes emotion or drama.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How does a photographer control lighting? How do you do it on a device?**
You can use a light or position yourself facing/away from the sun or the light source
- **Lighting is very important, especially in portraits. What is the best way to light a person's face if you want them to look more youthful?** *Front lighting is flat and therefore it shows a face as it is with hardly any shadows*
- **How does lighting change the feeling of the subject in the photographs above?**

Depth of Field: *Pink Cherry Blossom*, Meric Dagli/*Sakura Tree in Bloom*, Jelleke Vanooteghem



Photographers can decide the amount of the image that is in sharp focus and what is blurred. Sometimes you want the subject to be clear and crisp with everything else in the background blurred, like the cherry blossoms. This is a shallow **Depth of Field** which brings more attention to the subject. Other times you want the entire image to be in sharp focus or a deep **Depth of Field**. In the second photo you can see all the branches are in focus.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How can changing the depth of field in a photograph change the feeling/mood of it?**
- **What other photos do you see the photographer using Depth of Field to make the photograph more interesting?**

Placement: *Surfer Girl, GoPro image/Trojan, Bill Kallenberg*



Framing is a technique that photographers use while taking the photo to place an “Edge” or border around the main image or Focal Point. Things such as trees, archways, buildings, or mountains can be placed on both sides of the image to give it a natural “frame” thus emphasizing the object in the middle.

Cropping is done after the photo is taken. The photographer eliminates background clutter or “noise” by cutting it away so the subject becomes the definitive focus.

Suggested dialogue:

- **How did the artist draw your eye to the surfer?**
- **What do you think the artist might have cropped out of the photo of the tennis player? What effect did that have?**

PART 2: GROUP DISCUSSION (5 minutes)

Separate the class into 6 groups and give each group a Genre Folder

Directions for the group discussion:

- Read the description of the genre your group has been given.
- Look at the pictures in your envelope and choose one picture that your group will present to the class to help explain your genre.
- Brainstorm ideas for photographs your group will take in that genre.
- Assign a spokesperson to share your findings with the class.

PART 3: IPAD PHOTOGRAPHS (10 minutes)

Each group is given an iPad and is tasked with taking photos in their assigned Genre. They may want to stay inside the room or go outside (with adult supervision). Have each group take their “Elements of Photography” cheat sheet with them to remind them that they need to incorporate one or more Elements in their photographs. They have 10 minutes to take photos.

PART 4: PHOTO SELECTION AND MODIFICATION (5 minutes)

Students will convene in their groups for 5 minutes to select one photo they have taken that represents their Genre and that utilized one or more of the Photographic Elements. Students may choose to modify their photo by cropping, changing to black and white, etc.

PART 5: PRESENTATIONS (2-3 minutes/group)

- Each group will come up individually.
- They will first explain the Genre they were given and show the photo they selected from the packet to represent their Genre.
- Then the group will share their favorite photo from the pictures they took and point out which Element(s) of Photography were used.
- Docent can ask questions like, “How do you think that element of photography made the picture more interesting?” or “What other ideas did your group have for photos to represent your Genre?”

ACTION PHOTOGRAPHY - the genre of photography that captures people and objects in motion.

A large subset of Action Photography is Sports Photography. Other popular subjects could include moving vehicles and wildlife.

Depending on the exposure, lighting and filming technique used, the moving subject or background may appear clearly in focus or blurred.

Lightning quick reflexes, a strong sense of composition, good timing and more than a bit of luck are needed for successful action photography.



DOCUMENTARY PHOTOGRAPHY - a popular form of photography used to chronicle both historical events and everyday life.

This genre attempts to accurately describe or depict events, people, and places, and dates back to the earliest forms of photography in the 1850s. The first form, daguerrotypes depicted the American wilderness and ancient ruins in the Middle East. Matthew Brady used the new technology to photograph the [American Civil War](#) (1861-1865), the first conflict so documented.

New reproduction methods developed in the late 19th century meant that people were able to view the photos in books, newspapers, and magazines, which led to more photographers documenting more subjects.

President Franklin Delano Roosevelt's [Farm Security Administration](#), created in 1935 during the Great Depression, paid photographers and documentarians, including the legends [Walker Evans](#), [Dorothea Lange](#), [Russell Lee](#), [John Vachon](#), and [Marion Post Wolcott](#), to record the plight of their fellow Americans suffering during the economic collapse. Their photographic records informed citizens and elected officials with more drama and importance than did written reports about their needs.

Documentary and photo journalists transform records of daily life into an art form that can shine a light on people, places, and circumstances not often seen by the general American public. The photographer Thomas Ang called such documentary work, “the camera of conscience;” because it has often inspired changes in society.



LANDSCAPE PHOTOGRAPHY - the genre of photography that captures nature or landscapes.

Landscape photographs show no human activity and are created in the pursuit of a pure, unsullied depiction of nature devoid of human influence. They feature subjects such as strongly defined landforms, weather and ambient light. Good landscape photographs tell a story, show someone more than they see, share a feeling of a moment or remind people of the beauty of our world.

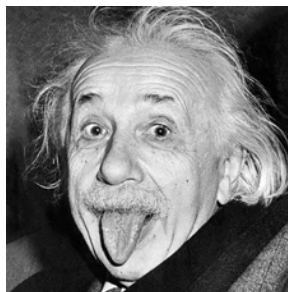
Some of the most important and celebrated landscape photographers have been motivated by an appreciation of the beauty of the natural environment and a desire to see it preserved. For example, Ansel Adams spoke passionately in defense of the natural world.



PORTRAIT PHOTOGRAPHY - the photography of a person or group of people that displays expression, personality, and mood or the subject. The focus of the photograph is usually the person's face, although the entire body and background or context may be included.

Portrait photography arose in the mid-nineteenth century as a faster and lower-priced alternative to painted portraiture. The style of these early works reflected the technical challenges associated with long exposure times and the painterly aesthetic of the time. Subjects were generally seated against plain backgrounds and lit with soft light of an overhead window and whatever else could be reflected with mirrors.

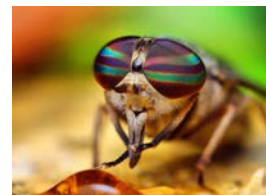
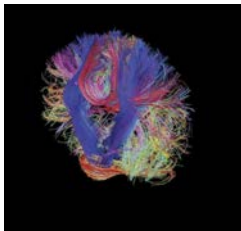
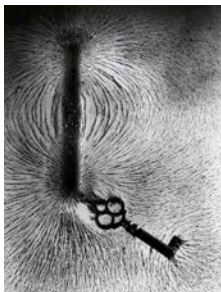
Advances in photographic equipment and techniques developed and gave photographers the ability to capture images with shorter exposure times and the making of portraits outside the studio.



SCIENTIFIC PHOTOGRAPHY - the genre of photography whose purpose is to capture and record scientific concepts, phenomenon, data and events.

Careful observation of evidence is the heart of modern scientific method; photography has always been valued as an objective technique of observation. Just as importantly, photography can gather data that can't be detected or processed by the human eye. Special lighting, extreme magnification, and even underwater equipment may sometimes be used to capture scientific images.

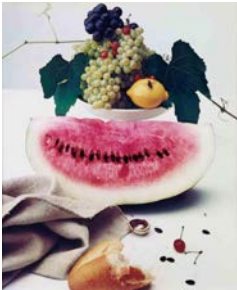
Using technology that captured the scattered path of invisible x-ray beams for example, Rosalind Franklin in 1952 was able to reveal the precise structure of intertwined DNA molecules – what we now recognize as the double helix. At the other end of the spatial scale, telescopic cameras can record galaxies located four billion light years away from Earth. Photography can also “slow down” events that are ordinarily too quick for the eye. In 1878, Eadweard Muybridge’s revolutionary photographs of a horse in motion settles a longstanding dispute about whether all four of a running horse’s feet are ever off the ground at the same time (they are). In the 1950’s, MIT physicist Harold Edgerton used a strobe light flash to capture stunningly beautiful images of the patterns made by a bullet passing through an apple, a drop of milk splashing into a glass and a hummingbird flapping its wings.



STILL LIFE PHOTOGRAPHY - the depiction of inanimate subject matter, most typically in a small grouping of objects.

The genre rose to popularity in the early 19th century and was inspired by the famous still life painters to the time (Goya, Cezanne and Van Gogh).

Lighting and propping, coupled with thoughtfully planned composition are the important elements of successful still life imagery. More so than other types of photography, such as landscape and portraiture, the still life photographer has a great deal of leeway in the arrangement of the design elements within the spot.



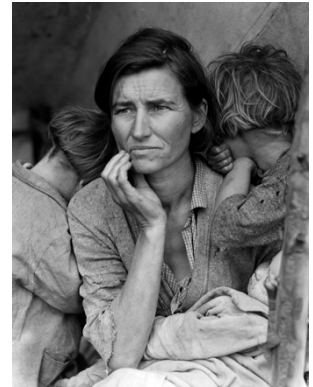
Parent Instructions for Photography

Thank you for volunteering today!

Please help by:

During the lesson

- Listen carefully to the docent instructions to the students
- The lesson begins with an overview of the elements of photography as a group.
- Then the students will break up into smaller groups to review a specific genre of photography. Please hand out an envelope to each group for this discussion
- Next, the small groups will take some photographs both inside and outside the class in their genre.
 - You can show them the rule of thirds on your cell phone
 - Help manage the students.
 - They should be quiet when going outside/coming back in.
 - Help keep them on track while outside.
 - When they return to the class, look at their photos. Ask them about their process. Be supportive of their attempts. Some will want to edit and that's ok. They all need one or two photos to share with the class.
- Finally, each group will present a photo or two that they took in their genre to share with the class.



Additional tips

- Ask Art Docents if a student needs extra help
- Try and make sure every student in the group has a chance to take a photo or be the director.
- Have fun!

Helping clean-up

- Please return the genre photos and definition cards to their respective envelope at the end.



Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
Spring 2015	Kathy Bonte, Mary Pat Gaspich, Sue Godfrey, Heather Johnson	Lesson was developed
May 2016	Heather Johnson	More suggested questions added to introduction, group discussion questions tweaked, one group presentation after photos are taken
November 2016	Heather Johnson	Additional pictures added for lighting
January 2018	Curriculum Committee	Group discussion questions remove so groups could focus on the elements of photography. Larger photographs made for genre photos.
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
June 2022	Yasmin Braun	Photos for introduction were changed and mounted.
June 2024	Curriculum Committee	Parent Volunteer Instructions Added
February 2025	Kimberly Dickerson	Updated instructions for Springer and Loyola to project photos